

Date: _____

August 24, 2026 · 5:00 – 7:30 PM · Kai Santos

NOTES

MECH 191 — Metallurgy · Week 1 Notes · fill in blanks & key terms as you go

Metallography Lab — Module 1

EXAMET-5-R-600-HD • 50-500x

Module 1 • Week 1

Atomic Structure & Bonding

What to do this week:

Observe grain boundaries at 100 $\times$. Sketch the grain network and estimate average grain diameter.

Steps:

- 1 Observe — complete feature table
- 2 Sketch — label magnification & specimen
- 3 Answer — 4 short questions

Specimens to Check Out

- Specimen A — 1018 low-carbon steel

How to check out the kit:

- 1 See instructor after class today
- 2 Sign out the specimen tray
- 3 Use the EXAMET-5 at your convenience
- 4 Return kit before leaving class
- 5 Submit completed module with your portfolio

Portfolio Handout — Module 1

SLIDE 3 *Metallography Lab — Module 1 EXAMET-5-R-600-HD · 50–500×*

NOTES

The science of metals — understanding structure, properties, and behavior so we can choose, test, treat, and work with them effectively.

Copper: abundant, conductive — but weak. Adding ~10-20% Tin disrupts copper's crystal lattice, creating Bronze: significantly harder and stronger than either metal alone, while keeping copper's workability and corrosion resistance. The first alloy in human history.

Pure metals rarely provide the properties we need. Alloys let us engineer the material for the job.

Adding a second element disrupts the crystal structure, blocking deformation and changing properties.

Carbon in iron → steel. Chromium in steel → stainless. Every unit in this course builds on this idea.

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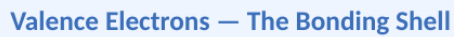
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Three key components:

Positive charge — inside the nucleus — defines the element (atomic number)

No charge — inside the nucleus — defines mass. Isotopes vary in neutron count.

Negative charge — orbit in energy bands/shells around the nucleus



The outermost electrons — the only ones involved in bonding. Carbon has 4 valence electrons, bonding in 4 directions simultaneously. This is why adding carbon to iron creates steel — carbon atoms sit between iron atoms and block deformation.

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Periods (Rows)

Groups (Columns)

Our Focus: Groups 3–12

Metals

Metalloids

Non-metals

- Poor electrical conductors
- Brittle (if solid) or gaseous
- Non-lustrous
- Tend to gain electrons

Atomic Bonding

The Octet Rule: Atoms are most stable with 8 valence electrons — they bond (lose, gain, or share electrons) to reach that stable state.

Metallic Bond

Metal + Metal

Electrons leave individual atoms and form a shared 'electron sea' — flowing freely through the structure.

Effect on material:

Conducts heat & electricity · Bends without fracturing · Atoms slide past each other

← Our primary focus

Ionic Bond

Metal + Non-metal

One atom gives away electrons; the other takes them. Creates oppositely charged ions that attract strongly.

Effect on material:

High melting point · Hard but brittle · Conducts only when molten or dissolved

Covalent Bond

Non-metal + Non-metal

Neither atom gives up electrons — they share them instead, forming strong directional bonds.

Effect on material:

Extremely strong · Poor conductors · Can be very hard (diamond = covalent network)

SLIDE 7 Atomic Bonding

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Crystal Structures — Unit Cells

When metals solidify, atoms arrange into repeating 3D patterns. The unit cell is the smallest repeating building block — like a tile in a tiled floor.

SC	BCC	FCC	HCP
Simple Cubic	Body-Centered Cubic	Face-Centered Cubic	Hexagonal Close-Packed
Packing: 52%	Packing: 68%	Packing: 74%	Packing: 74%
Ductility: —	Ductility: Low	Ductility: High	Ductility: Med
Atoms at 8 corners only. Teaching example — not found in real engineering metals.	Corners + 1 center atom. Stronger, less ductile. Fe (room temp), W, Cr, Mo, V	Corners + center + face atoms. Most ductile — most slip planes. Al, Cu, Ni, Fe (>912°C), Au, Ag	Same packing as FCC, fewer slip planes → less ductile. Ti, Mg, Zn, Co

SLIDE 9 Crystal Structures — Unit Cells

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From unit cell to bulk metal:

Single repeating building block (~0.3 nm). All atoms perfectly aligned.

Millions of unit cells — all with the same orientation. One crystal domain.

Countless grains packed together, each pointing a different direction.

Grain boundaries block dislocation movement — the mechanism by which deformation spreads through metal. More boundaries = stronger barriers to deformation.

A collage of nine overlapping squares in various shades of blue, green, brown, and purple, arranged in a non-uniform grid pattern. The squares are of different sizes and are layered on top of each other, creating a sense of depth and movement. The colors are muted and earthy, with some squares having thin white borders. The overall composition is abstract and modern.

Grain boundaries = white lines between regions

SLIDE 10 Grains and Grain Boundaries

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Key Takeaways

1 Metallic bonding explains metals

Shared electron sea → electrical and thermal conductivity. Non-directional bonding → ductility. This is what separates metals.

2 Navigate the periodic table

Transition metals (Groups 3–12) are the focus. Elements in the same column share behavior — useful for predicting alloy effects.

3 Structure exists at every scale

Atoms arrange into unit cells → unit cells form grains → grains make bulk metal. Each level determines performance.

4 Know BCC, FCC, and HCP

FCC is most ductile (74%, many slip planes). BCC is stronger but less ductile. HCP has 74% packing but fewer slip planes — less ductile than FCC.

SLIDE 11 Key Takeaways

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